

Buddhi Yoga as the Fastest Path to Clarity

A Synthesis of the Bhagavad Gita, Vedanta, and Yogic Psychology

Aarti Ravikumar

Introduction

Enlightenment, in the Bhagavad Gita, is not an escape from life but a clearer way of living within it. The Gita begins not with serenity, but with confusion: Arjuna stands overwhelmed, divided within himself. Swami Chinmayananda explains that this inner division is the split between *manas* (the reactive mind) and *buddhi* (the discriminative intellect), widened by ego and desire (Chinmayananda (n.d.)). When the mind and intellect are not aligned, action becomes anxious, fragmented, and clouded.

What obscures clarity, according to Vedanta, are *vasanas* — subtle latent impressions left in the mind by past actions, emotions, and desires. These impressions shape perception, trigger reactions, and create habitual tendencies. *Vasanas* are not just memories; they are energetic imprints that push us to repeat patterns unconsciously. When actions are performed with ego-centered desire, new *vasanas* accumulate. When actions are done selflessly, *vasanas* are exhausted.

Guided by Swami Chinmayananda’s commentary and Mahatma Gandhi’s interpretation of the Gita, this essay argues that *Buddhi Yoga* — the yoga of awakened intelligence — offers the most direct path to dissolving *vasanas*. By aligning a steady intellect (*buddhi*) with selfless action (*karma*), devotion (*bhakti*), inquiry (*jnana*), and meditation (*dhyana*), clarity naturally unfolds. (Gandhi, 2009).

What the Gita and Commentators Teach

Buddhi Yoga in Chapter 2 (2.39–2.41, 2.50)

After presenting *Sankhya* — the vision of the eternal Self (2.11–2.16) — Shri Krishna introduces *Buddhi Yoga* as the method for living that truth in action (2.39–2.41). He calls yoga “skill in action” (2.50). This skill is not technical efficiency; it is psychological integration.

Chinmayananda explains that the average person suffers because the manas reacts emotionally while the buddhi knows better. Ego-driven vasanas create this split (Chinmayananda (n.d.)).

Buddhi Yoga reunites these two aspects so the mind obeys discrimination rather than impulse.

When intellect guides action without attachment to outcomes, the personality becomes harmonious.

Thus, Buddhi Yoga is not withdrawal — it is clarity in motion.

Vasanas: The Real Obstacle

To understand why Buddhi Yoga is necessary, we must understand vasanas more clearly.

Vasanas are accumulated tendencies stored in the subtle mind. Every time we act with strong attachment, pride, fear, or desire, we leave behind an impression. These impressions influence future reactions. Over time, they build layers that cloud perception.

Chinmayananda compares this to dust on a mirror (Chinmayananda (n.d.)). The mirror does not need to create a reflection — it already reflects. The dust simply prevents clarity. Similarly, the Self is already pure awareness. Enlightenment is not gained; it is revealed when vasanas are reduced.

Actions performed with ego add dust. Actions performed selflessly remove dust.

Therefore, the fastest path to clarity is not acquiring more knowledge, but purifying the instrument of perception — the mind.

Four Accelerators of Buddhi Yoga

1) Selfless Action (Karma Yoga) — 2.47; 3.19

Shri Krishna instructs:

“You have a right to action alone, not to its fruits” (2.47).

“Therefore, perform action without attachment” (3.19).

This teaching does not promote passivity. It purifies motive.

When action is performed for praise, comparison, or fear of failure, anxiety arises. When action is offered as duty — dharma — the mind remains steady.

In my own life, this has been especially visible in academics. When I begin studying with the thought, “I must get the highest grade,” my mind becomes tense. But when I shift the focus to, “My dharma right now is to study with full attention,” the anxiety decreases. The work itself becomes absorbing.

This shift connects directly to:

Jnana — because I am discriminating between what is in my control (effort) and what is not (results).

Bhakti — because I mentally offer the work as service rather than ego-display.

During group projects, I have also noticed that attachment to recognition creates inner agitation.

When I consciously return to contribution rather than credit, collaboration becomes smoother.

Thus, Karma Yoga reduces vasanas by refining intention.

2) Devotion (Bhakti) — 12.8–12.12

Chapter 12 emphasizes steady remembrance of the Divine (12.8) and offers graded practices, culminating in renouncing attachment to results (12.12).

Devotion stabilizes emotion.

In family disagreements, I often feel a strong urge to prove I am right. But remembering 12.12 — valuing selfless action over rigid opinion — has helped me pause. Instead of arguing to win, I ask, “What response preserves harmony?”

One example occurred during a disagreement about household responsibilities. My first instinct was defensiveness. But reframing the moment as service — an opportunity to act without ego — softened my reaction. The conversation shifted from confrontation to cooperation.

Bhakti does not weaken intelligence; it humbles ego.

3) Inquiry (Jnana) — 2.52–2.53; 13.1–3

Inquiry clarifies identity.

In 2.52–2.53, Krishna explains that when discrimination becomes steady, confusion dissolves.

Chapter 13 distinguishes between:

The Field (body-mind complex)

The Knower of the Field (awareness)

This distinction has changed how I view emotions. When stress arises before an exam, I remind myself: “Stress is occurring in the mind; I am the one aware of it.” That small gap reduces identification.

Jnana is not collecting philosophy; it is seeing clearly.

4) Meditation (Dhyana) — 6.10–6.15; 6.35

Meditation is the sustained training of attention to rest steadily in awareness rather than wander through thought.

Krishna prescribes a quiet seat, balanced posture, regulated lifestyle (6.10–6.15), and acknowledges the restless mind — yet assures it can be restrained by practice and detachment (6.35).

Meditation is not forced suppression. It is the natural settling of a purified mind.

On days when I have acted selflessly and studied with attention, meditation feels lighter. On days filled with comparison or irritation, the mind feels heavier.

This shows that meditation is not isolated from daily life; it reflects it.

Sankhya and Buddhi Integration (Chapter 2)

Chapter 2 presents the full framework:

Arjuna's collapse (2.1–2.3)

The eternal Self beyond death (2.11–2.16)

Equanimity amid opposites (2.14–2.15)

Skill in action without attachment (2.47, 2.50)

Chinmayananda explains that Arjuna's crisis represents the split between reactive mind and guiding intellect (Chinmayananda (n.d.)). Buddhi Yoga repairs this split.

The teaching is not abstract metaphysics; it is psychological rehabilitation.

The Self is unchanging (2.16). But the mind, influenced by vasanas, fluctuates. Therefore, right knowledge must be applied through right action.

Sankhya provides vision.

Buddhi Yoga provides method.

My Practical Framework

Through reflection, I have adopted three small practices:

Before beginning work:

I name the dharma of the moment (“Study attentively” / “Serve without complaint”).

→ This connects to Jnana (clarity of role).

During action:

I watch for craving praise or fearing failure.

→ This connects to Karma Yoga (2.47).

After completion:

I reflect on what I learned rather than what I achieved.

→ This reduces ego reinforcement.

In friendships, this has helped me avoid reacting immediately when misunderstood. In extracurricular activities, it has made performance less stressful and more joyful.

These are small shifts — but they change inner atmosphere.

Conclusion

The Gita's "fastest path" is not a shortcut; it is simplification.

Align the intellect.

Purify motive.

Serve steadily.

Inquire deeply.

Meditate consistently.

As vasanas thin, perception clears. Study becomes learning. Service becomes joy. Meditation becomes natural.

Buddhi Yoga is not escape from life — it is intelligent participation in it.

For a student, this path is immediately practicable. Clarity does not require a forest or a cave. It begins in classrooms, conversations, and daily responsibilities.

Live fully — and with awareness, clarity, and deliberate purpose.

Biography

I am Aarti Ravikumar, a fourteen-year-old student who has spent the last eight years studying at Shishu Bharati. My academic journey has been defined not only by consistent effort and responsibility, but by a deep desire to grow in clarity and character. Through my study of the Bhagavad Gita, Vedanta, and yogic psychology, I have learned that true success is not measured solely by achievement, but by awareness, integrity, and self-mastery. I strive to apply these teachings in my daily life—transforming exams into opportunities for equanimity, family interactions into practice for selfless service, and challenges into lessons in resilience. I believe education is most powerful when knowledge and character evolve together, and I am committed to living that integration with sincerity and purpose.

References

Bhagavad Gita. (n.d.). In classical Hindu scripture (Original work ca. 2nd century BCE).

Chinmayananda, S. (n.d.). *Holy Geeta*. Central Chinmaya Mission Trust.

Gandhi, M. K. (2009). *The Bhagavad Gita according to Gandhi* (J. Strohmeier, Ed.). North Atlantic Books.

Shishu Bharati School

February 23, 2026